MANALIVE EXPEDITION

THE JOURNEY

WEEK 3
THE POSER

MIND THE GAP

DRAFT FOR REVIEW

October 12, 2026

WEEK 3 OVERVIEW

WHAT THIS WEEK IS FOR

Week 3 walks a man back through Friday's Poser session so he can see how he hides, without having to fix it yet. This week is recognition, not resolution. By Sunday he should be able to say:

> *I do pose. I can see some of the ways I hide, and God isn't disgusted with me for it. I'm not finished, and I don't have to be. I want to know what's underneath.*

HOW EVERY DAY WORKS

READING	About 150 words. A quick reminder of what happened at camp and where it shows up at home.
AUDIO	About 2 minutes from John. A handle to carry, one layer deeper, and a story.
WITH DAD	4 minutes on weekdays this week, up from 3 in Week 2. Saturday is 6. Sunday is 3.
SHARE	Optional. Opens the alumni group with his thought ready to paste.
NOTES	Private. Day 21 shows him this week's notes in one place.
WEEKLY EMAIL	Sunday evening. One heart line per day.

THE WEEK AT A GLANCE

DAY	TITLE	CARRY THIS	WITH DAD
15 · Mon	Free in Theory	**Mind the gap**	4 min
16 · Tue	Survival Mode	**He's not disgusted with me**	4 min
17 · Wed	Career Day	**Puff up or shrink back?**	4 min
18 · Thu	The Version They See	**I do that**	4 min
19 · Fri	The Fig Leaf	**Afraid, so I hid**	4 min
20 · Sat	Until It Doesn't	**It works until it doesn't**	6 min
21 · Sun	Underneath	**Honest beats impressive**	3 min

FREE IN THEORY

READING

Last Sunday I left you with a question: *If this is the story, why am I not living like a free man?*

That's exactly where camp went next.

Remember how the Poser session opened? Maximus, walking through the wheat toward home. Free. Nothing left to prove.

Then one question, and the room got quiet: *Are you actually living like a free man?*

Not in theory. On a Tuesday. At work. In your kitchen.

Most of us believe we're free. We've heard it. Some of us could quote the verse. But there's a gap between the freedom we believe in and the way we actually live. Guarded. Careful. Managing what people see.

Hear this: the gap isn't proof you're a fraud. Every man in that room had one. Noticing it is the first honest step.

This week we look at it. Not to fix it. Just to see it.

> CARRY THIS
> **Mind the gap.**

AUDIO SCRIPT JOHN

> I want to start this week with a moment I felt free.
>
> A couple of months ago we went to Gulf Shores. I'm standing on the beach. The sun is beating down on my skin. I can smell the salt. Sand under my feet. And the sound of those waves, crashing, over and over.
>
> There's something about how big that ocean is, and the sound of those waves, that just brings me peace.
>
> Nothing to hide. Nothing to prove. Just me.
>
> Now think about your normal Tuesday. For most of us, it doesn't feel like that. We're guarded. Watching what we say. Making sure nobody sees too much.

That's the gap. Between the freedom you believe in and the freedom you're living.

Jesus said if the Son sets you free, you'll be free indeed. Indeed. Not in theory. On a Tuesday.

So why does it feel so far away? That's this week. And I won't rush you to the answer, because you can't step over a gap you won't look at.

On the London subway, a voice comes on at every stop. Mind the gap. It's not yelling at you. It's just telling you it's there.

That's what I want you to carry today. Mind the gap.

When you feel yourself tighten up today and put on the face, just notice. There it is. No fixing. No beating yourself up. Every man has one.

Then take it to Dad. Ask Him where you're living smaller than free. He's not keeping score. He wants to look at it with you.

Mind the gap.

WITH DAD 4 MINUTES

Ask Him: *Father, where am I living smaller than free?* Then listen. If one thing comes, write it down. If nothing comes, that's okay. You started looking.

SHARE

Where do you feel most free? A place, a person, a thing you do.

YOUR NOTES

SURVIVAL MODE

READING

Right after that freedom question, camp got real about Act Three.

Life is hard. You were born into a war, and most days it shows up as pressure. Bills. A boss. A marriage that takes work. A kid you can't reach. A body that's starting to slow down.

And under pressure, men learn to survive. We guard. We hide. We check out. We overdo it. Nobody sits down and decides to do that. It just works, so we keep doing it.

That makes sense. It isn't the whole story, but it makes sense.

Then camp said something most of us needed to hear before we went one step further: God is not standing back in disgust, waiting for you to clean up. He is fiercely committed to getting you back. And He needs you in this story.

That's why you can look honestly this week.

You're not looking alone.

> CARRY THIS
> **He's not disgusted with me.**

AUDIO SCRIPT JOHN

> Let me tell you what survival mode looks like for me.
>
> Before our Arkansas camp this year, I had taken on way more than I needed to. I was trying to get ManAlive going, and at the same time I was trying to get my wife Amanda's first book published.
>
> And I put so much pressure on myself to do it all. So I just pushed through. Late nights. Kept every plate spinning. Did it myself, instead of leaning on the team that was there to help me.
>
> Nothing in that was me deciding to be fake. It was me getting through.
>
> That's how it starts for all of us. Something works under pressure, so we do it again. And after enough years, it doesn't feel like something we do. It feels like who we are.

> And when you start seeing that in yourself, a voice shows up fast. Look at you. God must be so tired of you.
>
> That is not His voice.
>
> Picture a dad who gets the call that his son's truck is in a ditch at midnight. He's not on the porch with his arms crossed. He's already got his keys.
>
> That's closer to the Father. He's not disgusted. He's committed. Fiercely. Not to the version of you that has it together. To you.
>
> And He needs you. Act Three needs men. Not perfect men. Men who are actually in it.
>
> **So here's what I want you to carry today. He's not disgusted with me.**
>
> When you catch yourself in survival mode today, say it. Then you can look at what you're doing without flinching.
>
> Take it to Him. Ask Him how He sees you on the days you're just getting through.
>
> He's not on the porch. He's on His way.

WITH DAD 4 MINUTES

Ask Him: *Father, how do You feel about me on the days I'm just surviving?* Then listen. If the first voice you hear is harsh, that's not Him. Ask again.

SHARE

One word for how life has felt since camp.

YOUR NOTES

CAREER DAY

READING

Remember the laugh? City Slickers. Career day at school.

First, Mr. Morelli. Loud. Sure of himself. Taking up the whole front of the room.

Then Mitch. Flat at the microphone, telling a classroom full of kids that life only goes downhill from here. You could watch their little faces fall.

The whole room laughed. Then it got quiet. Because a lot of us saw ourselves up there.

Those are two of the most common ways a man shows up when he's not sure he measures up. Puff up: louder, harder, more. Or shrink back: flat, checked out, just getting through the day.

Neither one is the real thing. Both keep anybody from seeing what's going on inside.

Most of us lean one way. Some of us switch depending on the room. Puffed up at work, flat at home. Or the other way around.

Today, just notice which one shows up.

CARRY THIS

Puff up or shrink back?

AUDIO SCRIPT JOHN

When I was a young guy, a bunch of us went out to play paintball.

Now, had I ever held a gun in my life? No. But I'm gonna win. Watch this.

So we get out there, everybody's shooting at everybody, and I find a tree. Perfect. I get behind it. And I hear a guy coming. And I'm thinking, oh, he is dead.

Pow. Right in the back.

I spin around. Ow. Hit in the front.

Shot from both sides. In a real war, I'm the first guy dead.

I laugh about it now. But look at what I did. I walked in puffed up. I got this. And the minute it got real, I was hiding behind a tree.

Both moves. About thirty seconds apart.

That's what we do. When a man isn't sure he's got what it takes, he either acts bigger than he feels, or he makes himself smaller so nobody can test him. Mr. Morelli or Mitch. A lot of us are both, depending on the day.

Puffing up sounds like talking louder. Winning the argument. Making sure everybody knows how busy you are.

Shrinking back sounds like going quiet. Whatever you want, babe. Not trying, so you can't fail.

Neither one is a crime. But both are a cover. And both keep the people closest to you from meeting the real you.

So here's what I want you to carry today. Puff up or shrink back?

Today you'll walk into a room that makes you feel small. A meeting. A family dinner. A conversation you've been avoiding. Notice what you do. Just notice.

Then take it to Dad. He's not fooled by either one. And He's not going anywhere.

WITH DAD 4 MINUTES

Ask Him: *Father, when I don't feel like enough, do I puff up or shrink back?* Then: *Show me one place I did it this week*. Listen. It doesn't have to be a big moment.

SHARE

Mr. Morelli or Mitch: which one got the bigger laugh out of you?

YOUR NOTES

THE VERSION THEY SEE

READING

Good Will Hunting. The bar near Harvard.

Chuckie pretending he belongs there. The guy with the ponytail showing off everything he's read. And Will taking him apart with the genius he hides behind everywhere else.

Everybody at that bar was posing. Even the smartest guy in the room.

That's what a poser is. The version of you that you put out there so nobody sees the one underneath.

And it doesn't always look like a tough guy. It can look funny. Nice. Busy. Religious. Competent. Agreeable. Successful. Invisible. Every man has his own.

Then two men stood up and told the truth about theirs. Where it showed up. What it cost them. Maybe one of them sounded a little like you.

That's the moment this session was after. Not *posers exist*. This: *I do that*.

If you're not sure yet what yours is, that's okay. You're looking. That's enough for today.

> **CARRY THIS**
> **I do that.**

AUDIO SCRIPT JOHN

> Remember that Arkansas camp I told you about, when I took on way too much? Here's the part I left out.
>
> People kept asking how I was doing. And I told them I was busy. I never told them I needed help.
>
> Busy sounds strong. Needing help doesn't. So that's the version I let them see.
>
> And it cost me. Registration started forty minutes late, because I wasn't ready. And when one of the guys came to help, I didn't yell at him, but close. I told him the best thing he could do for me right then was go away and leave me alone.

I handled it poorly. And a guy who showed up to help me got pushed away by the guy pretending he didn't need any.

For a long time, I didn't think of that as posing. I thought it was just how I am. That's the tricky part. From the inside, a poser doesn't feel like a mask. It feels like your personality.

Here's a plain way to say it. Your poser is whatever you do so people see the version of you that you want them to see. It shows up when you feel exposed. When somebody might find out you're not as together as you look.

And no two are the same. One guy cracks jokes. One guy goes quiet. One guy can't stop helping. One guy has to be the most spiritual man in the room.

I can't tell you which one you are. You'll know it when you see it. A small moment. You feel yourself reach for it, and something in you goes, oh.

That's what I want you to carry today. I do that.

That's not a confession. It's recognition. You can't take off something you don't know you're wearing.

So when you catch it today, just say it. No speech to yourself. No five-step plan.

Then tell Dad. Not because He doesn't know. Because He wants you to see it with Him, instead of alone.

WITH DAD 4 MINUTES

Ask Him: *Father, show me one way I pose.* Just one. Then listen. If it stings a little, that's okay. He's not showing you to shame you.

SHARE

Funny guy, tough guy, nice guy, busy guy, quiet guy. Which one do you lean toward? Keep it as light as you want.

YOUR NOTES

THE FIG LEAF

READING

Where does a poser come from? Camp took us back to the garden.

Adam and Eve eat the fruit, and the first thing they do is cover up. Fig leaves. Then they hear God walking in the garden, and they hide in the trees.

God calls out: *Where are you?*

And Adam gives maybe the most honest answer in the whole story: *I was afraid, because I was naked, so I hid.*

Afraid. Exposed. So he hid.

We've been sewing fig leaves ever since. A big leaf we call a personality. "That's just how I am." A job title. A joke. A smile in the church parking lot.

Here's the thing about a fig leaf. It's always covering something. Fear. Shame. Something we don't want anybody to see.

We're not digging that up today. Just notice it's there.

And notice this too: God didn't stay away. He came walking in the garden, looking for His son.

> CARRY THIS
> **Afraid, so I hid.**

AUDIO SCRIPT JOHN

> Let me show you what a fig leaf looks like on a normal day.
>
> A buddy asks how things are at home, and you say, "Good, man. Just busy."
>
> Your wife says you seem off, and you say, "I'm fine. Just tired."
>
> Somebody gets close to the thing that actually hurts, and all of a sudden you've got a joke. Or a question for them. Or somewhere you need to be.
>
> None of those are lies, exactly. That's what makes them work. They sound like facts. Like you're just being honest. But a lot of the time, "I'm fine" or "that's just how I am" is a fig leaf. It keeps anybody from asking the next question.

Here's what gets me about Adam. He didn't hide because he was a cartoon villain. He hid because he was afraid. And the first thing a scared man does is cover up.

So when you catch yourself posing, don't start with, what's wrong with me? Start with, what am I afraid of right now?

You don't have to answer that all the way. There's something underneath. We'll get there. For now, it's enough to know the leaf is covering something.

And don't miss the other half. God came walking in the garden. He knew exactly where Adam was. He asked anyway. Not to catch him. To call him out of the trees.

So here's what I want you to carry today. Afraid, so I hid.

When you reach for a leaf today, say it. That one sentence is more honest than most of us get in a week.

Then let Dad ask you what He asked Adam. Where are you? And tell Him. Leaf and all.

WITH DAD 4 MINUTES

Let Him ask you: *Where are you?* Answer Him honestly, leaf and all. Then be quiet and let Him be with you there. You don't have to come out of the trees all at once.

SHARE

Fig leaves come in all shapes. What's one you see a lot of guys wear?

YOUR NOTES

UNTIL IT DOESN'T

READING

The last clip of the Poser session was Jerry Maguire.

Jerry has it all. Top agent. Big clients. Everybody's friend. Then one night he can't sleep, and he can't fake it anymore. He writes down what he really thinks. Not long after, he's fired, walking out of the office holding a goldfish, asking, *"Who's coming with me?"*

His pose worked. Right up until it didn't.

And just before that clip, camp asked the question underneath every pose: *Do I have what it takes?*

Every man asks it. Most of us never say it out loud. We just answer it the best way we know. Prove it. Hide it. Stay where we know we can win.

We're not answering that question this week. Don't let anybody hand you a quick answer, including you.

It's Saturday. Take it to the Father, the way you walked out alone into the Covenant of Silence.

> **CARRY THIS**
> **It works until it doesn't.**

AUDIO SCRIPT JOHN

> Back in the first week, I told you there was a season when my life looked fine from the outside, and underneath I was living a double life. I want to tell you what that was.
>
> On the surface, it all worked. I was successful at my job. My wife and I did things together. If you'd met me, you'd have thought, that guy's got it together.
>
> Underneath, I was looking at porn about three hours a day. I was cheating on my wife. I was a sex addict. I thought about it constantly, and nobody knew.
>
> I had good friends. Guys who would have helped me. I hid it from every one of them.
>
> The pose and the secret needed each other. The better I looked, the less anybody asked. The less anybody asked, the deeper it went.

I've said it for years. The worst thing that can happen to a man who's posing is that his poser works. Because if it works, why would you ever give it up?

Mine worked. Until it didn't. It cost me my marriage. It cost me a job.

And under all of it was that question. Do I have what it takes? I didn't feel like a real man. So I built something that looked like one, and hid the rest.

I'm not telling you this so you'll see how far I've come. I'm telling you because some of you are where I was. It's working. Nobody knows. And you are tired.

So here's what I want you to carry today. It works until it doesn't.

If your pose is working right now, that's not good news. And you don't have to wait for the night it all comes apart. You can start by being honest with Him.

So take six minutes today. Go somewhere alone, like the Covenant at camp. Phone off. Ask Him the question you've been answering on your own. Dad, do I have what it takes?

Then be quiet. Don't answer it for Him. Write down whatever comes, even if it's just that you asked.

It works until it doesn't. You don't have to wait.

WITH DAD 6 MINUTES

Like the Covenant at camp: alone, phone off. Ask Him: *Dad, do I have what it takes?* Don't answer it for Him. Stay quiet, and write down what you notice, even if it seems small. Don't worry about whether it "counts." If nothing comes, that's okay. You asked Him instead of faking it.

SHARE

Who's a man you know who's the real deal, no pose? Tag him or tell us about him.

YOUR NOTES

UNDERNEATH

READING

Three weeks home.

This week you looked at something most men never look at. The gap between free and how you actually live. The pressure that taught you to survive. Mr. Morelli and Mitch. The bar in Good Will Hunting. The fig leaf. Jerry, walking out with a goldfish.

And maybe, somewhere in there, a quiet *I do that*.

If you saw a lot, that's okay. If you saw a little, that's okay too. Recognition comes in pieces. You don't have to be finished.

Your notes from this week are right below. Read back through them. You might see more than you thought.

Today, rest.

And if a question is following you around, let it: *Why do I do that? Where did it come from?*

Tomorrow we start there.

> **CARRY THIS**
> **Honest beats impressive.**

AUDIO SCRIPT JOHN

> Let me walk you through an ordinary Sunday with your eyes open.
>
> Somebody at church, or at breakfast, asks how your week was. You feel the face go on before you even answer. There it is. I do that.
>
> Lunch with the family. Your brother-in-law's talking about his new truck and his promotion. You feel yourself get louder. Or go quiet. Puff up or shrink back?
>
> Afternoon, your wife asks you a real question. And you crack a joke. Or you say, that's just how I am. Fig leaf.
>
> Tonight, the house gets quiet, and the pull to check out is strong. Afraid, so I hid.

None of those moments is a disaster. That's the point. Most posing isn't dramatic. It's small, and it's all day long.

But here's what's different. You saw it. A month ago, you wouldn't have. That's not failure. That's a man waking up.

So here's what I want you to carry into this week. Honest beats impressive.

Impressive gets you admired from across the room. Honest lets somebody actually know you. Your wife. A few good men. Your Father.

And if this was a week you mostly saw a lot of posing and not much else, good. That's honest. That's exactly the week it was supposed to be.

Today, rest. Read back through your notes. And sit with the question I left you. Why do I do that? Where did it come from?

We'll start there tomorrow. Honest beats impressive.

WITH DAD 3 MINUTES

Ask Him: *Father, what did You show me about me this week?* Then tell Him: *I want to know what's underneath*. And just be with Him.

SHARE

One line about your third week home.

YOUR WEEK IN THE APP: HIS NOTES FROM DAYS 15 TO 21, FILLED IN

Same as Day 7: each note he wrote this week, with the day, the "Carry this" line, and the With Dad question. Only days he wrote show up.

YOUR NOTES ON DAY 21

SUNDAY EVENING, AFTER DAY 21

THE WEEK 3 EMAIL

Same template as Week 1. Only the seven day lines are new.

From: The Journey <jpulley@manaliveexpedition.com>
Subject: Week three is in the books. You're caught up.

Mike,

Three weeks home. Maybe you did every day. Maybe you missed a few. Either way, you're not behind, and there's nothing to apologize for. Here's the heart of the week, in case any of it slipped by.

Day 15, Free in Theory. You believe you're free. Most of us don't live like it yet. The gap isn't proof you're a fraud. Mind the gap. Reread Day 15 ›

Day 16, Survival Mode. Life is hard, and men learn ways to survive it. God isn't standing back in disgust. He's fiercely committed to you. Reread Day 16 ›

Day 17, Career Day. When a man isn't sure he measures up, he puffs up or shrinks back. Mr. Morelli or Mitch. Most of us are both. Reread Day 17 ›

Day 18, The Version They See. Your poser is the version of you that you put out there so nobody sees the one underneath. The goal isn't fixing it. It's three words: I do that. Reread Day 18 ›

Day 19, The Fig Leaf. Adam hid because he was afraid. So do we. And God still comes walking in the garden, asking, where are you? Reread Day 19 ›

Day 20, Until It Doesn't. Every pose is trying to answer one question: do I have what it takes? A pose can work for years. It works until it doesn't. Reread Day 20 ›

Day 21, Underneath. Recognition comes in pieces, and you don't have to be finished. Honest beats impressive. Reread Day 21 ›

Your notes from this week are waiting for you on Day 21. Only you can see them.

Read your week ›

That's the week. If you just read this, you're caught up. Tomorrow we start fresh.

Strength and Honor,
Pulley

FOR YOUR REVIEW

DECISIONS MADE IN THIS DRAFT

- **Recognition, not resolution.** Days 15 to 20 follow the session in order: the freedom gap (Gladiator), Act Three and God's commitment, City Slickers, Good Will Hunting and the responders, the fig leaf, then Jerry Maguire and "Do I have what it takes?" Day 21 is the landing. No day tells him how to fix his poser.
- **Day 16 puts Act Three and God's Fierce Commitment together,** so he hears "He's not disgusted with me" before he looks hard at himself. That's the order the session uses: hope before exposure.
- **The wound stays closed.** Day 19 says the fig leaf is covering something (fear, shame) and stops there. Day 21 leaves "Why do I do that? Where did it come from?" for Week 4 without teaching it.
- **"Do I have what it takes?" is asked, never answered.** Saturday's With Dad has him ask the Father and not answer it for Him. "Am I loved?" is left out, since the spec still lists it as an open leadership call.
- **Day 20 uses the held Poser story (the double life),** picking up Week 1 Day 2's one-line mention. It's written from your notes, plus three details from your 2019 TX Wound talk: you hid it from good friends, it cost you your marriage and a job, and you didn't feel like a real man. It doesn't mention strip clubs or prostitutes (also from that talk). **Please confirm you're comfortable with "three hours a day," "cheating on my wife," and "sex addict" in a daily audio.**
- **Day 17's paintball story is retold from your 2024 AR Beauty talk** ("Had I ever held a gun in my life? No. But I'm gonna win."). It fits here because you puffed up and then hid, 30 seconds apart. Confirm, and check that Beauty week isn't using it too.
- **Two lines from your 2019 TX talk:** "The worst thing that can happen to a man who's posing is that his poser works" (Day 20) and "a big leaf we call a personality" (Day 19).
- **Clip details to confirm:** I took the Poser's Good Will Hunting clip to be the Harvard bar scene (your 2019 talk mentions "the clip earlier of Ben Affleck and those guys"). "It's not your fault" stays saved for Wound week. City Slickers names Mr. Morelli as the big talker, per the spec. Jerry Maguire is written as the sleepless night, getting fired, and walking out with the goldfish.
- **4 story slots** (Days 15, 16, 18, 19). Day 16's slot asks for a pressure season other than the divorce, since Week 2 told that one. Day 21 uses an ordinary-day walk-through instead of a

story. The scripts around each slot are about 225 to 255 words, so keep each answer to 30 seconds or so to stay near 2 minutes.

- **No slot for the jail story.** The Poser doesn't need it. It may fit Wound or Battle better.
- **Unused stories from your talks** you could swap into a slot: humor as your way to look cool (Beauty 2024), the social butterfly who meets 20 people in an hour but lets none of them in (Band of Brothers 2019), and your first-camp prayer, "You better speak to me" (Wound 2019). I left them alone because they may belong to later weeks.
- **With Dad grows** to 4 minutes on weekdays (Week 2 was 3), 6 on Saturday, 3 on Sunday. Saturday is set up like the Covenant of Silence: alone, phone off, write down what comes, don't worry whether it "counts."
- **The responders** get one mention, unnamed, in Day 18's reading.

OVERALL NOTES ON WEEK 3